

1. Understanding AI and Generative AI in the Classroom

As a pre-primary teacher, I see Artificial Intelligence (AI) not as a distant tech concept, but as a friendly digital helper. AI is broadly the capability of machines to mimic human thinking and problem-solving. Generative AI takes this a step further: it is a creative assistant that can generate brand-new content like stories, images, and lesson plans based on simple text prompts.

In early childhood education, these tools are practical everyday aids. For instance, I use generative text tools to instantly draft differentiated phonics worksheets tailored to different reading levels in my kindergarten classroom. Another common application is image generation, where I prompt AI to create customized visual flashcards featuring diverse characters and animals that match our weekly theme, such as a friendly jungle safari. These applications save precious planning hours while making learning materials much more inclusive and engaging for young learners.

2. AI and Education: Impact and Risks

Integrating AI into education brings transformative benefits alongside notable risks. On the positive side, AI acts as a powerful collaborative partner, drastically reducing administrative burdens, enabling hyper-personalized learning plans, and generating endless creative resources for diverse learners.

However, significant risks remain. AI systems frequently exhibit biases learned from training data and are prone to "hallucinations" confidently presenting completely fabricated facts or inappropriate pedagogical content. For young children, over-reliance on digital tools could diminish essential social-emotional interactions and critical thinking development. Therefore, educators must maintain strict human oversight, treating AI as a co-pilot rather than an autonomous decision.

3. Reflecting on AI Tools: Evaluation and Critical Thinking

Recently, I used ChatGPT to generate a weekly thematic lesson plan focused on sharing and emotions for my four-year-old students. While the overall structure was creative, the tool initially suggested activities requiring children to sit and listen attentively for twenty consecutive minutes—an unrealistic expectation for pre-primary attention spans.

This minor miscalculation highlights why educators must evaluate AI critically. Generative models lack real-world classroom intuition and developmental psychology expertise. To verify accuracy and fairness, I always cross-reference AI suggestions against established early childhood development frameworks (like NAEYC guidelines) and screen for cultural inclusivity.

For educators and learners alike, critical evaluation is non-negotiable. Accepting AI outputs blindly risks introducing factual errors, cultural biases, and developmentally inappropriate practices into vulnerable learning environments. We must model healthy skepticism so children learn early that technology is a tool to question, not an absolute authority.